and influence have widened eastwards at this very time. The conceptualization of the Indo-Pacific and the emergence of the Quad are examples of a contemporary response to emerging demands. They also underline the importance of not according a veto to others on sovereign choices.

When it comes to India–China relations, references are often made to it being the foundation of an Asian century. This goes back to some remarks that were made by Deng Xiaoping more than three decades ago. Events of the last few years, however, point to the converse reality that their inability to get along can jeopardize such prospects. The search for a modus vivendi, therefore, becomes a quest for multipolarity in Asia. And that, in turn, has evolved into a larger debate about exercise of choices, concerns about the global commons, respect for international law, and an engagement on the basis of sovereign equality. In its economic dimension, there is a parallel debate underway on the need for fair trade, the importance of equal opportunities, the compulsions of risk mitigation, and building resilient and reliable supply chains while promoting trust and transparency.

In the games that nations play, political romanticism and cultural pride can often become manipulative cards. Forging a united front against the West and suggesting that Asia must be for Asians are tried-and-tested tactics that appeal to the insecurity of the post-colonial world. The reality, however, is remorselessly unsentimental and much more competitive. In a globalized world, keeping others out while seeking access to their regions is unrealistic. In a strategic one, partners should be chosen on interests and not on the basis of sentiments or prejudices. A more culturally assured India would surely see the difference.

India’s answers for a more balanced and stable relationship with China lie in a range of options across multiple domains. Given the developments of 2020, they obviously centre around an effective defence of the border. This was undertaken even in the midst of Covid. A fitter and more technology-enabled military is evidently the need of the day. Peace and tranquillity on the border areas clearly remain the basis for normal relations. This is far from equating it with resolving the boundary question. The reality is that even this lower bar was breached in 2020! Economically, further progress in expanding manufacturing and promoting ‘*atmanirbhar* Bharat’ is key. Internationally, building more relationships and promoting